

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 9 8
 ♥ Q 5 2
 ♦ 9 7 5 4
 ♣ Q T 6

♠ K 6 5 4 2
 ♥ A K 8 7 4
 ♦ A
 ♣ K 3



♠ Q J T 7 3
 ♥ J 3
 ♦ 8 6 2
 ♣ J 9 5

♠ -
 ♥ T 9 6
 ♦ K Q J T 3
 ♣ A 8 7 4 2

West	North	East	South
	1 ♠	Pass	2 ♦
Pass	3 ♥	Pass	4 ♥
Pass	4NT	Pass	6 ♥
All Pass			

6 ♥ by North

if they don't split 3-2 you will have two trump losers. So you assume that they are split just like you need them to be.

At trick two you duck a trump. That's right, you lose a trump trick early. Since you have to lose a trump sometime, you do it at a time when the defenders can't hurt you. So a defender wins the trump trick, but now a ♠ play won't hurt because dummy still has a trump to ruff with! In fact, whatever they play next you will win, pull the outstanding trumps, then run dummy's ♦ suit.

This is a very rare play, but a good one to remember.

When you have a trump loser but still need to pull their trumps, it may be better for you to lose an early trump trick rather than a later one.

South's 6 ♥ response to Blackwood showed one Ace and a ♠ void. North is to play 6 ♥. East leads the ♠ Q.

Losers: ♠ = ?? ♥ = 1 ♦ = 0 ♣ = 0 Total = 1 ??

Of course you ruff the ♠ in dummy. East wouldn't underlead an Ace at a slam contract, and since you have a certain trump loser you cannot afford to lose a trick to West's ♠ A.

Dummy has some great ♦ s, but you can't expect to run them unless you have pulled all the trumps. But if you play ♥ A K 4 the defenders will take their trump trick and immediately set the contract with the ♠ A. There **IS** a way around the problem.

First off, you must get a 3-2 split in trumps because

Board 2

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ A K Q
 ♥ A K 9 8
 ♦ A T 8 6 3
 ♣ 5

♠ 6 5
 ♥ 5 4 3 2
 ♦ Q 2
 ♣ K Q 9 7 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 7 4 2
 ♥ Q J T 7
 ♦ 5
 ♣ A 8 6 4 2

♠ J T 9 8 3
 ♥ 6
 ♦ K J 9 7 4
 ♣ J T

West	North	East	South
1♦	Pass	1♥	Pass
4NT	Pass	5♦	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			
6♥ by East			

Agreed that the bidding wasn't much. The final contract is still a good one. East is to play 6♥. South leads the ♠J.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=0 ♣=4 Total = 4

There really aren't 4 ♣ losers since they can be ruffed in dummy. In fact you should see that this is an ideal cross-ruff hand, ruffing ♣s in dummy and ♦s in your hand. Since neither hand can be over-ruffed you expect to make all 8 trumps.

Remember, when playing a cross ruff, you need to take any side suit winners first, otherwise a defender may be able to discard that suit while you are ruffing. So you win the ♠A, then take the ♠K, then . . . what?

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Well, if you win the ♠Q, then the two Minor suit Aces, you'd be set up to cross-ruff the hand out for all 13 tricks. But here's what might happen if you try.

North might ruff the ♠Q. OK, no disaster yet. But he might then play a trump. Your slam is now kaput. You can no longer make 8 trump tricks and will end up down 1.

The answer is to not be greedy for that overtrick. With South's opening ♠ lead there is an indication of possible length there. So, realizing that North could be short in the suit, take just the 2 ♠ tricks that you need for the slam, then play your Minor Aces and start the cross-ruff.

When playing a cross-ruff you must take all the side-suit winners you need early so they won't get ruffed later.

Don't jeopardize your contract trying to take too many.